

The square of a pawn is a race shortcut

Chess Math

THE IDEA

For a freely advancing pawn, compare its remaining moves to promotion with the defending king's distance to interception squares. The familiar square rule visualizes this race. Side to move, the initial double push, blockers, and king support can alter the answer.

WORKED EXAMPLE

A white pawn on a5 needs three pushes to reach a8. A black king on d5 can enter the a5-d8 square and catch an unsupported pawn if its route is clear. A king farther away may fail by one tempo.

TRY IT BEFORE READING ON

Why must you ask whose move it is before using the square rule?

ANSWER AND REASONING

Because the pawn may advance before the king enters the catching area. One tempo can turn an equal-distance race into a promotion. Verify the actual move order near the boundary.

TAKE THIS INTO YOUR NEXT GAME

A race calculation starts with the move count and the turn.